

FOR TIRED DADS RUNNING ON EMPTY

The 5-Minute *Present* Dad

Five small ways to show up for your kids — even on the days you've got nothing left to give.

Present, not perfect.

A guide from **Dad's Code**
by **Jamie Wigg**

— THE WHY

You don't need to be a perfect dad. You don't need more hours, more patience, or more energy than you've got. You need **five minutes** — and the willingness to actually be **in** them.

I'm Jamie, a dad of four who spent years feeling like I was failing. Here's what actually moved the needle.

WHY THIS WORKS — THE RESEARCH

It isn't about doing more

- Kids don't need more *time* — they need *attention*. Psychologists call the small everyday moments "bids for connection" (Gottman); responding to them is what builds secure attachment.
- Brief, fully-present moments register more than long, distracted ones.
- For a burnt-out or neurodivergent dad, *tiny and repeatable* beats *big and occasional* — every time.

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*You don't need **more hours**.*

FIVE SMALL THINGS

Start tonight

1

TIP ONE

The 5-Minute Rule

Give one child **five minutes of your whole attention** — phone away, eyes up, their choice of what you do. Five present minutes beats an hour of half-watching.

WHY IT WORKS Undivided attention signals "you matter," which research links to stronger secure attachment than time alone.

TONIGHT

Say *"You've got me for five minutes — what do you want to do?"*

2

TIP TWO

Catch the Bid

Kids constantly throw out little "bids" — *"Dad, look at this!"* Most get half a grunt. **Turn toward one bid fully today.** Stop, look, react like it matters. To them, it does.

WHY IT WORKS Gottman found relationships thrive on how often we "turn toward" these small bids, not on grand gestures.

NEXT "DAD, LOOK"

Drop everything for 20 seconds.

3

TIP THREE

The 6-Word Reset

When you feel the snap coming, don't push through it. Pause and tell yourself: *"They're not giving me a hard time — they're having one."* Then respond to the feeling under the behaviour.

WHY IT WORKS Naming the emotion calms your own stress response, so you react from the thinking brain, not the reflex.

EVERY TIME

One deep breath before you react.

4

TIP FOUR

Repair Beats Perfect

You'll lose it sometimes. Every dad does. What kids remember isn't the slip — it's whether you came back. **Apologise to your kid:** *"I got that wrong, I'm sorry."* It teaches more than never failing ever could.

WHY IT WORKS "Rupture and repair" research shows it's the repair, not flawless parenting, that builds trust and resilience.

NEXT TIME YOU SNAP

Repair it, out loud.

5

TIP FIVE

One Small Ritual

Presence sticks when it's a habit. Build one tiny ritual that's *yours* — a handshake, a song, the "air cuddle" my son and I do (ears pressed together, no words). It costs nothing and they'll carry it forever.

WHY IT WORKS Predictable rituals create felt safety and become anchors of connection kids return to for years.

THIS WEEK

Invent one two-second ritual.

— THE CLOSE

Five minutes, starting tonight

That's it. Five small things, five minutes,
starting tonight. Being present beats
being perfect — **always.**

Want more? The podcast **Dad's Code** drops weekly
— real, honest fatherhood, no perfect-parent act.
When you're ready for the next step, grab "*Present,
Not Perfect: A Rebuilt Dad's Field Guide.*"

Show up for your kids — even on the days you've got nothing left.

- ✓ 5 tiny, repeatable habits you can start *tonight* — no extra time required.
- ✓ Built for tired, busy, neurodivergent dads — short, plain, no lectures.
- ✓ Backed by real psychology (attachment, bids for connection, repair) — not hustle-culture fluff.

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— DAD'S CODE

Present, not perfect.

This guide shares personal experience and general parenting ideas for support and encouragement only. It is not medical, psychological, or therapeutic advice. If you or your child are struggling, please speak to a qualified professional.